Caught up in the Rapture

By Sheneska Jackson

I'm just about sick and tired of all this sneaking around like I'm some two-year old child. I mean, look at me. I'm twenty-six years old and still breaking out in a cold sweat because I'm afraid Daddy won't let me go out tonight. He'll probably break out into tone of his holy chants.

DAD: "Oh, Lord, save this child. Make her see the error of her evil ways!"

By the time he's finished, I'll feel so guilty that I'll get dressed in one of my little white dresses and follow right behind him to the Holy Sight Baptist Church. Or at least that's what usually happens, but not tonight. Tonight I've got big plans and nothing, not the good Reverend Deems, not even the Almighty Himself is going to stop me. Today Dakota called me up at work and said she had two tickets to Black Tie Records' annual executive party. If I could just get my tape into the hands of somebody, anybody, at that company, I'd be set.

INTRODUCTION

Jazmine Deems wants to reach for the stars, gain success and have a music career that is elusive to other people who only dream. Jazmine can do more than dream, however . . . she can SING! Her father, a Baptist preacher, feels if she goes after a career in music she will end up like her mother – alcoholic, irresponsible and gone. Her father wants her to stay in college, get a "real" career, and pray for her very soul. Neither dream is unreasonable . . . but for Jazmine – the dream to sing supersedes the wishes of her father. Sometime you just have to let yourself get Caught up in the Rapture by Sheneska Jackson

Okay now, let's see. I've got my hot curlers, my makeup kit, and my good panties: "demon material." My best friend Dakota says I'm weak when it comes to daddy, but she just doesn't understand. I envy Dakota, I really do. Dakota's parents were musicians. They treated the two of us to a concert. I told Daddy we were going to see a young gospel

group. He was glad that I was "becoming closer to the Lord." I got to my seat, the house lights went off, and the crowd could barely contain themselves. A lady behind me began shouting, "Go on girl, sang that song." Then the man next to her stood up and started hollering too, "Sang it, baby, sang it!" And then it happened. Anita Baker walked into the spotlight, standing less than five foot three, but seeming larger than life. I was in awe. At that moment, I knew what I wanted to do. I wanted to sing. I wanted to get onstage in front of thousands of people and touch them deep down in their souls the way Anita touched me. I wanted to make people yearn, make their hearts bleed, move them, make them feel. That was eight years ago. (to God) I'm still waiting for my dreams to come true, just in case you were wondering! But get this, I got a phone call the day after the executive party.

BOBBY: "I'm Bobby Strong of Black Tie Records, and I'd like to meet with you this afternoon to discuss your future here at Black Tie. I have an opening in my schedule at four o' clock, and by the way, your friend Colorado was right, your voice is impeccable! Don't thank me. Thank your friend Colorado."

I wanted to tell him her name was Dakota, but HELL, he could call her Alaska if he wanted to! I quickly got dressed, but before I got out the door, Daddy stood in the doorway glaring at me.

DAD: "I just got back from church and Miss Ola told me her son Oliver saw you at a party last night. Girl, you ought to be shamed."

JAZMINE: "Just stop it, Daddy. All I did was go out to a little party. What is it? Do you think I'm going to go out one night and never come back? Do you think I'm momma? I'm not momma!"

DAD: "Jazmine, who do you think you're talking to? Jazmine, don't you dare walk out that door, girl!"

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I kept right on walking. At that moment I felt like the force of God was within me, but that couldn't be possible, because of the way I had just spoken to Daddy, I knew God wouldn't want to be with me right now. I got to Black Tie Records . . .

BOBBY: "Now Jazmine, I just want to hear your voice. Give us a little somethin', somethin'."

JAZMINE: Okay Mr. Strong

(Sings) **Ah, ah, ah, ah, ah, ah, caught up in the rapture of love. . .**
(Sing for ~20 seconds Check out http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IUb3HjFEq6Y for the melody)

When I finally opened my eyes:

BOBBY: "Jazmine, it's only a matter of time before that voice lands you on the Billboards."

I did it. I had finally made my dreams come true, and you know what? I did it all by myself. That night, by the time I reached the steps, Daddy had opened the door and looked out.

DAD: "Come fix you a plate."

I fixed myself a place and sat at the table.

DAD: "You any good?"

JAZMINE: "Yeah."

DAD: "Better than your momma?"

JAZMINE: "Yeah."

I knew we weren't talking about voice quality or music arrangement. We were comparing lifestyles. I'm smart enough to know that drugs can't make me any more artistic than I already am. I'm smarter than Billie Holiday, smarter than Janice Joplin, and yeas, smarter than Momma. Daddy lifted my hands to his face and kissed my palms. I felt closer to him that I ever had before. You see, at that moment, my father wasn't the Great Reverend Deems, healer of lost souls; he was finally just my Daddy.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier – DI
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